

Examining the Ethical Implications of Data Privacy and Targeted Advertising in Digital Marketing: Consumer Perceptions

1st Mohammad Khalaf Daoud
Applied Science Private University
Amman, Jordan
mo_daoud@asu.edu.jo

2nd Daoud Marzouq Al-Qeed
Al Ain University
Abu Dhabi, UAE
Marzouq.alaqeed@aaau.ac.ae

3rd Jassim Ahmad Al-Gasawneh
Applied Science Private University
Amman, Jordan
J_algasawneh@asu.edu.jo

4rd Abdulkrim Ziani
Al Ain University
Abu Dhabi, UAE
Abdulkrim.Ziani@aaau.ac.ae

Abstract— Purpose: Examining the Ethical Implications of Data Privacy and Targeted Advertising in Digital Marketing: Consumer Perceptions" is to investigate and analyze the ethical considerations surrounding the utilization of consumer data for targeted advertising in the digital marketing landscape. Design/Methodology/Approach: This approach combines both qualitative and quantitative methods to provide a holistic understanding of consumer perspectives and attitudes. Findings: The research "Examining the Ethical Implications of Data Privacy and Targeted Advertising in Digital Marketing: Consumer Perceptions" reveals consumer concerns regarding data privacy and targeted advertising in digital marketing. Participants are apprehensive about personal information use, emphasizing the trade-off between personalization and privacy. Conclusion: This study highlights the intricate relationship between data privacy, targeted advertising, and consumer perceptions in digital marketing. Ethical transparency and trust are pivotal considerations for responsible marketing practices. Practical Implications and Contribution to Literature: This research offers practical insights for marketers to balance data privacy and targeted advertising ethically. It contributes to the literature by addressing consumer perceptions, guiding responsible digital marketing strategies.

Keywords— Ethical Implications, Data Privacy, Targeted Advertising, Digital Marketing, Consumer Perceptions.

I. INTRODUCTION

The widespread availability of consumers' personal information has several effects. These effects encompass susceptibility to fraud; encroachments on privacy, unwelcome marketing solicitations, and the emergence of highly targeted and intrusive marketing efforts that disrupt daily routines [1]. Nonetheless, the advantages to consumers resulting from information utilization initiatives are often highlighted. By skillfully employing consumer data, it becomes possible to offer personalized products, suggest recommendations, provide price cuts, deliver complimentary services, and offer marketing content that is more pertinent. In theory, marketers can extend additional benefits to consumers due to their enhanced ability to operate efficiently with improved information [2]. These patterns have led to an increased emphasis on safeguarding consumer privacy, drawing attention from scholars, societal commentators, and regulators [3]. The associated costs and benefits for both

marketers and consumers are substantial and warrant deeper examination. Hence, we tap into the extensive marketing literature concerning privacy and consumer data utilization, in addition to insights from information systems, legal studies, ethics, and other related fields. This allows us to capture the current state of knowledge as well as the areas that require further exploration in this domain Martin & Murphy [4]. Monitoring consumer movements during their shopping ventures is not a novel occurrence. For a considerable time, marketers have gathered data to aid in decision-making, observing activities like selecting strawberries or the thought process parents undergo when choosing a cereal box. Consumers seem unperturbed by this intrusion into their privacy, likely due to their public setting and the nature of the data being collected details about their cart contents, eventual purchases, and products they examine are easily noticeable. This indifference could stem from the assumption of being anonymous; their shopping habits are amalgamated for pattern analysis. [5], At the point of sale, customers can voluntarily participate by using a personal shopping card, credit card, or check [6]. Presumably, they knowingly trade some privacy for benefits like product discounts, credit, future coupons for frequently bought items, and such. Anonymity endures if they employ cash and decline to provide their phone number, address, or zip code. However, this anonymity undergoes a transformation when consumers transition to the online realm. Their shopping actions are no longer solely accessible in an aggregated form. Instead, individual activities are traced, and data is amassed from their online purchases as they navigate through websites. The value exchange between marketer and consumer becomes less clear-cut in this new digital retail landscape compared to the traditional physical store environment. The ensuing questions outline the apprehensions stemming from this alteration in transaction venues Caudill & Murphy [7]. As a measure of results, worries regarding privacy seem to be on the rise over the years for both younger and older consumers. However, the increase is more pronounced among older consumers, as indicated by Daoud research in 2023 [3]. This research makes notable contributions by shedding light on the ethical considerations in digital marketing, offering practical insights for marketers, and adding to the literature on this important topic. It also raises awareness of the ethical dimensions of

data privacy and targeted advertising in the digital marketing landscape.

II. REVIEW OF LITERATURE

A. Ethical Implications of Data Privacy and Targeted Advertising

The contemporary landscape of digital advancements has given rise to intricate ethical and legal discussions regarding privacy-invading practices employed by prominent high-tech corporations. This phenomenon is notably highlighted by the actions of technology giants such as Google, Facebook, Apple, and Amazon, collectively referred to as "Big Tech," whose ethically contentious behaviors have attracted substantial global attention from governmental bodies and the general public alike. These controversies underscore two central concerns regarding the strategies enacted by these entities [8]. Primarily, these corporate giants, along with their counterparts, have amassed substantial reservoirs of personal data extracted from users of their services. These accumulated datasets are not solely utilized for internal purposes like research, development, and promotional activities, but are also disseminated to other entities for diverse applications in product marketing and advertising. This practice, known as "data mining," which involves scrutinizing individual preferences, behaviors, and tendencies, can potentially infringe upon an individual's privacy rights, even when consent for data collection has been granted initially Carbone [9]. Furthermore, Jacobson et al. [10] demonstrated that the widespread accessibility of social media platforms has led to the generation of a substantial data repository, which marketers are leveraging to glean valuable insights for strategic decision-making and digital marketing endeavors. Despite this, a deficit in established professional norms governing the usage of social media for marketing purposes exists, along with a gap in understanding how comfortable consumers are with marketers accessing their social media data. Notably, research has unveiled a correlation between consumers' perceptions of the risks and benefits associated with social media usage and their level of comfort with marketers employing their publicly shared social media data. Daoud [8] his exploration extends the boundaries of the communication privacy management theory into the realm of social media, introducing a novel construct known as "marketing comfort." This concept, crucial for future marketing inquiries, signifies an individual's ease with the utilization of publicly accessible social media information for activities like targeted advertising, customer interactions, and sentiment analysis. Notably, within this construct's developmental process [11]. It becomes apparent that targeted advertising possesses the most pronounced influence compared to the other dimensions of opinion mining and customer relations. These advancements in social media utilization have also given rise to significant changes within the business sphere. Analogous to the transformations shaping individuals' lives, acquisition of knowledge, and establishment of connections via social media Gruzd [12], the integration and adoption of social media platforms have triggered substantial shifts within the business landscape. Consumers are harnessing these platforms to create and share information, exchanging experiences not only among peers but also with companies

and broader online communities, employing various mediums such as posts, tweets, shares, likes, and reviews Bailey [13] and Al-Gasawneh [14].

B. Consumer Perceptions

The concerns about the adoption of Internet marketing among specific groups of individuals due to past experiences, as highlighted by Daoud [6], have not only affected the reception and acceptance of Internet marketing but are also part of a broader context of marketing practices. Marketing strategies have historically aimed to engage consumers in economic transactions. Over time, marketers have strived to anticipate consumer buying patterns and customize advertisements for identifiable individuals. However, this practice has consistently raised debates due to its potential to be perceived as ethically questionable and manipulative, as discussed by Watkins & Hill [15]. As the landscape evolves, the emergence of data mining and computational inference has introduced novel and unsettling ways of targeting vulnerable demographics. This has led to the weaponization of prediction and marketing techniques, where automated predictions significantly enhance the precision and subtlety with which marketing efforts can be directed at consumers [3]. This heightened targeting ability substantially increases the likelihood of enticing consumers into transactions for products they may not truly require, have not considered before, or which could potentially harm them. Sher [16] categorizes potential vulnerabilities in this context into three distinct groups: emotional vulnerabilities (such as feelings of social inadequacy, neuroticism, and psychological conditions) [6], perceptual vulnerabilities (involving distortions in perception and comprehension of objects and situations), and cognitive vulnerabilities (encompassing limitations in thinking and memory processes). In a specific case from 2019, Google's actions and the subsequent resolution with the Federal Trade Commission and New York State's attorney general underscore the growing significance of data privacy. Google's agreement to pay a significant fine and implement changes to protect children's privacy within its YouTube application demonstrates the regulatory concern over the exploitation of personal data, especially when targeting vulnerable populations. Regulatory authorities concluded that YouTube had violated the Children's Online Privacy Protection Act (COPPA) by illicitly collecting children's personal information and profiting from targeted advertising aimed at them, as highlighted by Singer & Conger [17]. This serves as an illustration of how the evolving landscape of marketing practices intersects with legal and ethical dimensions, impacting consumers' privacy and the broader societal discourse [11].

III. RESEARCH METHOD

A. Research Design

This investigation adopts a mixed-methods research approach, integrating qualitative and quantitative methodologies to conduct a comprehensive exploration of the ethical ramifications linked to data privacy and targeted advertising within the domain of digital marketing. The focal point is the consumer perspective on these matters.

B. Research Philosophy

An interpretive research philosophy guides this study, acknowledging the subjective nature of consumer

viewpoints. The emphasis lies in attaining a profound comprehension of the underlying meanings and motivations that underpin consumer attitudes toward data privacy and targeted advertising.

C. Data Collection

Qualitative Phase: During this phase, this endeavor was undertaken through an exhaustive examination of prior literature, encompassing a wide array of facets pertinent to the subject matter. **Quantitative Phase:** The quantitative aspect necessitates the availability of a questionnaire tailored precisely for this objective, which has undergone scrutiny and validation by experts within this scientific domain. This questionnaire will comprise Likert scale and closed-ended queries, aiming to gauge participants' viewpoints, inclinations, and anxieties concerning data privacy and targeted advertising. Employing both descriptive and inferential statistical techniques, a comprehensive analysis will be conducted on the collected survey data [11].

D. Sampling

Qualitative Phase: Selective purposive sampling methodology will guide the selection of participants, aiming for demographic diversity and variance in digital marketing exposure. A target sample size of X participants will be sought, with data saturation determining the final count of interviews and focus group sessions. **Quantitative Phase:** A representative sample of Y participants will be drawn from an appropriate population via random sampling techniques. Rigorous efforts will be undertaken to ensure a well-distributed representation across diverse demographic variables, thereby enhancing the potential generalizability of findings.

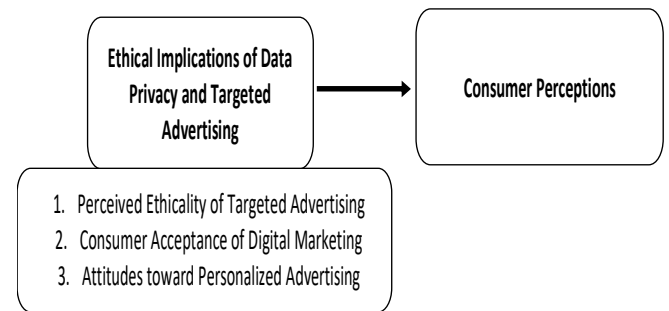
E. Data Analysis

This section presents the empirical findings of this research. The analyses are conducted using the statistical technique discussed earlier. This section follows the widely accepted reporting style of PLS-SEM analysis as suggested by previous studies [18]. Prior to subjecting the data sets for the structural equation modeling procedures, the data sets are first screened for multivariate assumptions to ascertain conformity before engaging in the model quality assessment, and after that, validating the structural model. Since this study involves assessing the mediation effect of electronic services quality on mobile marketing and customer satisfaction relationship analysis is conducted to examine this effect. This section finishes with a summary of the findings [19].

F. Ethical Considerations

The study scrupulously adhere to ethical guidelines, ensuring informed consent is secured from all participants. The confidentiality and anonymity of participants will be rigorously upheld throughout every facet of the research process.

G. Study model



H1: There is a significant impact of Perceived Ethicality of Targeted Advertising on Consumer Perceptions.

H2: There is a significant impact of Consumer Acceptance of Digital Marketing on Consumer Perceptions.

H3: There is a significant impact of Attitudes toward Personalized Advertising on Consumer Perceptions.

IV. ANALYSIS OF THE RESULTS

A. Profile of Respondents

400 cases were retained for analysis. The demographic composition of participants, including gender, age, and education level, is presented in Table 1. The table illustrates that the majority of participants identified as male (59.1%), while the remaining 40.9% identified as female. Concerning age distribution, the highest proportion fell within the 18 to 27 years bracket (21.9%), followed by the 38 to 47 years group (21.6%), with the lowest representation in the 68 and above category (8.9%). In terms of educational attainment, the majority held a Bachelor's degree (61.5%), followed by diploma holders (15.9%), while individuals with a PhD constituted the smallest portion (4.2%).

TABLE I. PROFILE OF RESPONDENTS (N=400)

B. Measurement Model Assessment

Variable	Category	Frequency	Percent (100%)
Gender	Male	236	59
	Female	164	41
Age	18-27	88	22
	28-37	69	17.25
	38-47	86	21.5
	48-57	65	16.25
	58-67	58	14.5
	68-over	34	8.5
Educational Level	High school	34	8.5
	Diploma	64	16
	Bachelor	246	61.5
	Master	39	9.75
	PhD	17	4.25

In the current study, the model estimation offers empirical measurements of the associations between the indicators and constructs. The sequence for the algorithmic modeling of Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM) entails evaluating the reliability of items, internal consistency, convergent validity, and discriminate validity of all construct scores.

1) Internal Consistency Reliability

Internal consistency reliability pertains to the degree to which all items within a specific scale measure the same underlying concept, as outlined by Sun [20]. Historically, Cronbach's alpha has served as the benchmark for assessing internal consistency [21]. Nonetheless, researchers have noted that Cronbach's alpha assumes uniform reliability across all indicators and often underestimates internal consistency. Due to these limitations, Composite Reliability has emerged as a more suitable metric, accounting for variations in the outer loadings of indicator variables. In Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM), emphasis is placed on indicators with higher individual reliability [22].

Table 2 presents the internal consistency of each construct, surpassing the recommended threshold of 0.7, in accordance with the guidelines of Hair [23].

TABLE II. INTERNAL CONSISTENCY RELIABILITY ANALYSIS

Dimension	Cronbach's Alpha	Composite Reliability	AVE
Perceived Ethicality of Targeted Advertising	0.908	0.914	0.581
Consumer Acceptance of Digital Marketing	0.860	0.872	0.720
Attitudes toward Personalized Advertising	0.857	0.879	0.610

2) Convergent Validity

The AVE results exhibit coefficients ranging from 0.635 to 0.846, affirming the attainment of convergent validity for all constructs. Moreover, the assessment of composite reliability also reveals values spanning from 0.877 to 0.925. Unlike Cronbach's alpha, Composite Reliability is favored by contemporary researchers due to its sensitivity to the number of items in a scale, avoiding an assumption of indicator equality and thereby mitigating underestimations of internal consistency reliability [21]. However, the presentation also includes Cronbach's alpha values, ranging from 0.782 to 0.910.

Given the established convergence validity, which validates item loadings meeting stipulated criteria, along with satisfactory AVE and composite reliability, it can be reasonably concluded that the items effectively represent their corresponding constructs, thus solidifying their convergence validity.

3) Discriminant Validity

As posited by Gholami, Sulaiman, Ramayah, and Molla (2013), achieving discriminate validity hinges upon the distinct differentiation between various constructs and the extent to which indicators are uniquely associated with a single construct. A precise assessment of discriminate validity holds paramount importance to ascertain the statistical distinctiveness of a given construct from others (Hair, Risher, Sarstedt, & Ringle, 2017).

It is asserted that a HTMT (Heterotrait-Monotrait Ratio of Correlations) value exceeding 0.85 signals a significant concern in terms of discriminate validity (Henseler, Ringle, & Sarstedt, 2015). However, the Fornell-Larcker criterion, as well as the HTMT values, are displayed in both Table 4.3 and

Table 4.4. Fornell and Larcker [24] argued that discriminant validity is achieved when the correlation between latent constructs is less than the square root of the corresponding AVE placed within diagonal cells, with correlations being lower than this threshold.

TABLE III. DISCRIMINANT VALIDITY BASED ON FORNELL-LARCKER CRITERIA.

Fornell-Larcker Criterion		
	Ethical Implications of Data Privacy and Targeted Advertising	Consumer Perceptions
Ethical Implications of Data Privacy and Targeted Advertising	0.676	
Consumer Perceptions	0.382	0.632

TABLE IV. DISCRIMINANT VALIDITY BASED ON HTMT RATIO OF CORRELATIONS

Heterotrait-Monotrait Ratio (HTMT)		
	Mobile Marketing	Consumer Perceptions
Ethical Implications of Data Privacy and Targeted Advertising		
Consumer Perceptions	0.413	

C. Structural Model Assessment

TABLE V. R² VALUES FOR THE ENDOGENOUS LATENT VARIABLES

Endogenous Variable	R ²	Predictive Relevance
Consumer Perceptions	0.375	

TABLE VI. THE Q² VALUES FOR THE ENDOGENOUS LATENT VARIABLES

Endogenous Variable	SSO	SSE	Q ² (1-SSE/SSO)
Consumer Perceptions	7680.000	7452.173	0.030

TABLE VII. EFFECT SIZES (F²) OF THE LATENT VARIABLES

Variable	Endogenous Variable	f ²	Effect Size Rating
Ethical Implications of Data Privacy and Targeted Advertising	Consumer Perceptions	0.288	Medium

D. Path Coefficients Testing

In Table 8, the findings illustrate the testing of H1, H2, and H3.

TABLE VIII. RESULTS OF STRUCTURAL MODEL

No.	Hypotheses	Beta	SE	T-Value	P-Value	Supported***
H1	PETA→CP	0.337	0.050	6.746	0.000	Supported***
H2	CADM→CP	0.270	0.053	5.298	0.000	Supported***
H3	ATPA→CP	0.370	0.050	7.538	0.000	Supported***

***: p<0.001; Two tailed hypothesis; 5,000 bootstrap samples

H1: There is a significant impact of Perceived Ethicality of Targeted Advertising on Consumer Perceptions.; the hypothesis was supported.

H2: There is a significant impact of Consumer Acceptance of Digital Marketing on Consumer Perceptions.; the hypothesis was supported.

H3: There is a significant impact of Attitudes toward Personalized Advertising on Consumer Perceptions.; the hypothesis was supported.

V. DISCUSSION

The examination of ethical implications stemming from data privacy and targeted advertising within the digital marketing domain has yielded valuable insights into consumer perceptions. By employing a blend of qualitative and quantitative methodologies, we achieved a comprehensive analysis of the intricate dynamics at play. Our study has unveiled a multifaceted landscape where consumer concerns and attitudes intersect with contemporary marketing strategies.

Our findings underscore the critical importance of data privacy as a central apprehension for consumers navigating digital spaces. The ability of marketers to harness personal data for customized advertising has ignited concerns about potential privacy violations. Participants exhibited a nuanced comprehension of the trade-off between tailored experiences and potential breaches of privacy. This dichotomy highlights the intricate balance that digital marketers must navigate.

Consumer perceptions concerning the ethical aspects of targeted advertising revealed a spectrum of perspectives. While some participants recognized the value of receiving relevant advertisements, others expressed reservations due to perceived manipulation and exploitation inherent in such practices. The ethical dimension of utilizing personal data for profit emerged as a focal point, underscoring the significance of transparent communication and the establishment of trust between consumers and marketers.

The interplay between data privacy and targeted advertising has also cast a spotlight on considerations for the future of digital marketing. As technological advancements continue to mold the digital landscape, it is imperative for marketers to align their strategies with evolving ethical standards. Striking a balance between innovation and ethical responsibility becomes paramount to preserve consumer trust and loyalty in the long term.

VI. CONCLUSION

This research delved deeply into the ethical underpinnings surrounding data privacy and targeted advertising within the context of digital marketing, as perceived by consumers. Employing a mixed-methods approach, we illuminated the intricate interplay between consumer perceptions, ethical considerations, and marketing strategies.

Our study unequivocally confirms that data privacy stands as a paramount concern for consumers navigating the digital landscape. The juxtaposition of personalized experiences against potential privacy breaches underscores the need for judicious data collection and usage practices. The ethical implications of targeted advertising further accentuate the necessity of transparency and candid dialogue between marketers and consumers.

As the realm of digital marketing continues its evolution, practitioners must accord due recognition to the pivotal role that ethical considerations play in shaping consumer attitudes and behavior. Our research underscores the need for marketers to tread carefully, navigating the fine line between technological innovation, consumer privacy, and ethical responsibility.

In the ever-evolving panorama of digital marketing, the imperative of continuous dialogue and collaboration among stakeholders looms large. Establishing ethical guidelines that safeguard consumer trust and foster responsible marketing practices becomes a shared responsibility. This study adds to the ongoing discourse by illuminating the intricate dynamics of data privacy, targeted advertising, and their ethical ramifications within the digital marketing realm.

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